Greek Through Reading Excerpts

March 9, 2026

Adapted readings from J. A. Nairn & G. A. Nairn's *Greek Through Reading*, 1974 edition. This book is really special to me — it was a gift from Dr. Hendrickson, the Latin teacher at my high school who got me into Greek. I'd started studying in 2023 after taking his "How to Read Ancient Greek" mini class at summer camp. Two years later, in summer 2025, I took the same mini class, now having finished half of *Alpha to Omega*. He gave me the book there.

College apps prevented me from working through the book for most of 2025. Since I have more time now, I hope to work through most of its passages over summer 2026.

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I. Greece and Athens

1. Greece – J. A. Nairn

Ἡ Ἑλλὰς μέρος ἐστὶ τῆς Εὐρώπης. οἰκοῦσι δ᾽ αὐτὴν οἱ Ἕλληνας τοὺς πάλαι διὰ τοῦτο καὶ νῦν τιμῶμεν, ὅτι τήν τ᾽ ἐλευθερίαν ἐφίλουν, καὶ τὴν ἀλήθειαν, καὶ τὸ καλόν. καὶ ὑπὲρ μὲν τῆς ἐλευθερίας ὀλίγοι πρὸς πολλοὺς πολεμοῦντες πολλάκις ἐνίκησαν, τὴν δ᾽ ἀλήθειαν καὶ τὸ καλὸν ζητοῦντες ποιήματα καὶ δράματα καὶ ἱστορίας ἔγραψαν, καὶ ἀνδριάντας ἔγλυψαν καὶ ἱερὰ ᾠκοδόμησαν, ὧν ἔνια καὶ ἐφ᾽ ἡμῶν περίεστιν.

αὕτη ἡ βίβλος περὶ τῶν θ᾽ Ἑλλήνων καὶ περὶ τῶν ἔργων ἀπαγγελεῖ.

Greece is a part of Europe. And the Greeks live there. We now value the Ancient Greeks on account of these, because they were loving freedom, and the truth, and moral things[1]. And on account of freedom the few often conquered the many making war, and seeking truth and morals, wrote poems and plays and histories, and carved statues and erected shrines, of which some now are surviving in our time.[2]

This book will recount both the Greeks and their works.

2. The Sea – J. A. Nairn

Τῆς Ἑλλάδος οὐδὲν μέρος πολὺ τῆς θαλάττης ἀπέχει. μεταξὺ γὰρ τῆς Εὐρώπης καὶ τῆς Ἀσίας πολλαὶ νῆσοί εἰσι, καὶ ἐν τῇ χώρᾳ αὐτῇ πολλοὶ λιμένες, ὥστε οἱ ἀπ᾽ Εὐρώπης πρὸς Ἀσίαν πλέοντες γῆν ἀεί ποθ᾽ ὁρῶσιν· ἀγαθοὶ δ᾽ ὄντες ναῦται οἱ Ἕλληνες ἦλθον ἐπὶ τὴν Ἰωνίαν καὶ τὴν Λιβύην, καὶ Αἴγυπτον, καὶ δὴ καὶ ἐπὶ τὴν Βρεταννικήν, καὶ διὰ τοῦ Ἑλλησπόντου

No one of the Greeks is much far from the value of the sea. For between Europe and Asia there are many islands, and many ponds in the very countryside, so that those sailing from Europe towards Asia seldom see the land: and the Greek sailors, being good, came upon Ionia and Libya, and Egypt, and in fact upon Britain, and throughout the Hellespont upon the black

[1] Possibly a reference to democracy and philosophy in particular.

[2] Standard philhellene talk. Pretty exciting introduction!

ἐπὶ τὸν Εὔξεινον πόντον, καὶ ἀποικίας ᾤκισαν. ὡς καλὸν τὸ χρῶμα τῆς ἐκεῖ, τῆς Αἰγαίας θαλάττης! τῷ οἴνῳ προσόμοιον ἔφασαν εἶναι οἱ ποιηταί.

sea, and settled colonies. So beautiful is the color of that place, the Aegean sea! The poets said it was similar to wine.

3. The Land – J. A. Nairn

Μικρὰ δὴ χώρα ἡ Ἑλλάς· καὶ πολλὰ μὲν ὄρη ὀλίγα δὲ πεδία ἔχει, ποταμοὺς δ᾽ οὐ μακρούς. τὰ δ᾽ ὄρη, τοὺς Ἕλληνας ἀπ᾽ ἀλλήλων ἀποτέμνοντα, ἀπίστους πρός τοὺς ὁμόρους ἐποίει, ῥᾴδιον γὰρ οὐκ ἦν συνελθεῖν. καὶ πρὸς τοὺς ἔξω πολεμίους τοῦτο μέγαν κίνδυνον παρεῖχεν, ἐπεὶ οὐχ ὡς ἓν ἔθνος ἀλλ᾽ ὡς πόλεις ἑκάστη καθ᾽ ἑκάστην διῆγον. τῶν δὲ πόλεων ὀνόματα τῶν λαμπροτάτων γράψω· Σπάρτη, Ἀθῆναι, Θῆβαι, Ἄργος, Κόρινθος. ἐπολέμουν πρὸς ἀλλήλας αὗται αἱ πόλεις πολλάκις, εἰρήνην δ᾽ ἦγον οὐ πολλάκις.

The Greek land is small: on the one hand, it has many mountains, but it has few plains, and no large rivers. And the rivers, severing the Greeks from each other, were creating distrust against neighbors, for it was not easy to assemble. And this was a great danger outside of wars, because each lived according to each, not separated by race but by cities[3]. I shall write the names of the most famous cities: Sparta, Athens, Thebes, Argos, Corinth. These cities were often at war with each other, and were often not at peace.

4. Sparta and Athens – J. A. Nairn

Ἡ μὲν Σπάρτη ἔνεστιν ἐν τῇ τοῦ Πέλοπος νήσῳ, ἣν οἱ Ἕλληνες Πελοπόννησον ἐκάλουν· ἀπέχει δέ τι τῆς θαλάττης. στρατιώτας δ᾽ ἔτρεφεν ἀνδρείους, οἳ πόλεμον ἀπὸ παιδὸς ἤσκουν. ἔτι δ᾽ αἱ γυναῖκες αὐτῶν ἐν τοῖς γυμνασίοις ἔμαθον

Sparta is in the island of Pelops, which the Greeks call the Peloponnese – it is somewhat far from the sea. They raised brave soldiers, who trained for war from boyhood. Even the women of them [the Spartans] learned in the gymnasium to

[3] Unsure about this translation.

ἰσχυραὶ εἶναι, ὡς πρέπει ταῖς μητράσι στρατιωτῶν.

be brave, so that they would appear mothers of soldiers.

Ἀθῆναι δὲ τοὐναντίον [4] πρὸς τῇ θαλάττῃ εἰσίν, οἱ δ᾽ Ἀθηναῖοι πλεῖν τὴν θάλατταν ἔμαθον, ὡς ναῦται καὶ ἔμποροι. ἀπὸ δὲ τῶν νεῶν ἐμάχοντο, καὶ μεγάλην δύναμιν ἔσχον, θαλαττοκράτορες ὄντες.

Athens on the contrary is close to the sea, and the Athenians learned to sail the sea, just as sailors and wayfarers. And they fought from the ships, and held great power, being sea-masters.

5. Athens – J. A. Nairn

Ἔτι καὶ νῦν αἱ Ἀθῆναι λαμπροτάτη τῆς Ἑλλάδος πόλις· πῶς Ἀθήναζε ἐρχόμεθα· κατὰ θάλατταν ῥᾷον ἢ κατὰ γῆν. πλέοντες οὖν εἰς Πειραιᾶ ἀφικνούμεθα, τῶν Ἀθηνῶν λιμένα. ἆρα μέλλομεν, ὡς Σωκράτης χρόνῳ ποτε, πομπὴν ὁρᾶν· Πλάτων γὰρ ἔγραψεν ὡς ἐν Πειραιεῖ, ἐν τῇ θυσίᾳ θεοῦ τινος, Σωκράτους παρόντος, νεανίαι ἔδραμον [5] δᾶδας ἔχοντες ἐν ταῖς χερσί, καὶ τρέχοντες παρέδοσαν τὰς δᾶδας ἕκαστος τῷ πλησίον, καὶ ἐκεῖνος ὡσαύτως τῷ πλησίον, τοῦτο δὲ τῆς νυκτὸς ἐγένετο.

Even now Athens is the most magnificient city of Greece; how do we go to Athens? Easily by the sea or by earth. Then sailing, we arrive at Piraeus, harbor of athens. Are we about to see, just as Socrates once upon a time, the splendor? For Plato wrote that in the Piraeus, in the temple of some god, with Socrates present, the youth ran, holding torches in their hands, and running, handed over each torch to a bystander [6], and just so they to a bystander, and this took place by night.

6. The Acropolis – J. A. Nairn

[4] τὸ ἐναντίον : on the contrary

[5] Strong aorist of τρέχω

[6] Plato wrote about this torch ceremony in *Republic* (Book 1)

Ἐν δὲ ταῖς Ἀθήναις ἄκρα τίς ἐστιν, ἣν Ἀκρόπολιν ὀνομάζουσι· διατείνει δ᾽ αφ᾽ ἡλίου ἀνατέλλοντος ἐφ᾽ ἥλιον δύνοντα· ἐπὶ δὲ ταύτης τῆς ἄκρας ἱερά ἐστιν, ὧν τὸ μέγιστον Παρθενὼν καλεῖται, ἱερὸν γάρ ἐστιν τῆς θεοῦ Ἀθηνᾶς, ἣ παρθένος διέμεινεν. τετράγωνον δὲ τὸ ἱερόν, καὶ πολλοὺς ἔχει στύλους. ἐν δὲ τῷ ἄνωθεν μέρει ξόανά ἐστιν, ἔργον τοῦ Φειδίου. τῇ μὲν ἡ Ἀθηνᾶ γεννᾶται, θυγάτηρ οὖσα τοῦ Διός, τῇ δ᾽ ἐρίζει πρὸς τὸν Ποσειδῶνα, πότερος ἄρξει τῆς Ἀττικῆς

And in Athens is something tall, which they call the Acropolis: it faces away from the rising sun and faces the setting sun[7]. And upon this tall building are shrines, of which the greatest is called the Parthenon, for it is the shrine to the goddess Athena, who remains a maiden[8]. The shrine is four-sided, and has many pillars. And in the upper part are xoana [9], the work of Phidias. On the one side Athena is born, being the daughter of Zeus, on the other side she challenges Poseidon – which of the two should lead Athens.

7. Praise of Athens – Pindar, fr. 76, p. 556 (trans. Sandys)

Αἵ τε λιπαραὶ καὶ ἰοστέφανοι καὶ ἀοίδιμοι,
Ἑλλάδος ἔρεισμα, κλειναὶ Ἀθᾶναι, δαιμόνιον προλίεθρον.

O, the gleaming, and the violet-crowned, and sung in story:
the bulwark of Hellas, famous Athens, city divine.

8. Athens: The Parthenon – J. A. Nairn

Ἐπὶ δὲ τῶν τοῦ ἱεροῦ τειχῶν ἄνω λίθινα ζῷά ἐστιν, ἐν πομπῇ, τιμὴν φέροντα τῇ θεῷ Ἀθηνᾷ. ἐνθάδε μὲν οἱ θεοὶ ὁρῶσι τὴν πομπήν, Ζεύς τε καὶ Ἥρα καὶ Ἥφαιστος. καὶ μὴν καὶ ὁ Ἄρης, καίπερ τοῦ πολέμου θεὸς ὤν, μένει ἡσυχῇ. ἐκεῖ δ᾽ ὁ

And up along the walls of the shrine there are marble figures, in escort, doing honour to the goddess Athena. Here the gods see the pomp, Zeus and Hera and Hephaestus. And even Ares, although being the god of war, rests at peace. And there the

[7] The Parthenon's main entrance faces East.
[8] maiden – παρθένος . Parthenon – Παρθενών .
[9] wooden effigies

ἱερεὺς τῆς θεοῦ, πέπλον λαβὼν ἐν ταῖς χερσί, δίδωσι παιδί· νέος δ᾽ οὗτος ὁ πεπλος, ἀντὶ τοῦ παλαιοῦ τῇ θεῷ φερόμενος. πέμπουσι δὲ τὸν πέπλον νεανίαι, καὶ παρθένοι, [10] καὶ ἱππῆς, [11] καὶ αὐλητρίδες, [12] καὶ κιθαριστρίαι, [13] ἆρ᾽ ἑώρακας· ἔνεστι γὰρ ἔνια τῶν ζῴων ἐν τῇ πατρίδι ἡμῶν.

priest of the gods, holding garments in hands, offers children: this new garment is carried to the goddess in exchange for the old. Did you see the young men escort the garment, and maidens, and charioteers, and flute-players, and kithara-players? For some of the images are in our own country. [14]

8. Athens: The Marketplace – J. A. Nairn

Ἰδοὺ ἡ τῶν Ἀθηνῶν ἀγορά· μεστὴ δὲ περὶ μεσημβρίαν τῶν ὠνουμένων. πρῷ δ᾽ ἥκοντες ἑστᾶσι βλέποντες τό τ᾽ ἔλαιον καὶ τὸ ὄξος καὶ τοὺς πρὸς τὸ πῦρ ἄνθρακας, καὶ τοὺς πρὸς τὸ δεῖπνον ἰχθῦς. πολλοὶ δὲ τῶν παρόντων διαλέγονται ἀλλήλοις, νεώτερόν τι ἢ ἀκούειν βουλόμενοι. ἴσως δ᾽ ἀκούουσι τῶν σοφιστῶν τῶν διδασκόντων δὴ τὴν σοφίαν. ἆρα πάρεστι Σωκράτης· ναί, καὶ περιεστᾶσι πολλοί, ἐλέγχει γὰρ τοὺς σοφιστάς, καὶ φανερὸν ποιεῖ ὅτι δοκοῦντες εἰδέναι τι τῷ ὄντι οὐκ ἴσασιν.

Look at the marketplace of Athens: it is filled with buyers around midday. In the morning they stood gathering to see the olive oil and the vinegar and charcoal for the fire, and fish for the meal. Many on the boats conversed with others, wishing to hear something new. They lisen equally to the scholars and the ones professing to teach wisdom. Is Socrates present? Yes, and others avoid him, for he questions scholars, and shows clearly that those assuming to know something in reality do not know[15].

[10] maidens

[11] charioteers (cf. ἵππος "horse")

[12] flute-players

[13] kithara-players (κιθάρα : 7-stringed version of the lyre)

[14] The British Museum famously (and controversially) holds many of the Parthenon sculptures.

[15] A related quote appears in Plato's *Apology* 21d, where Socrates is quoted to say ἃ μὴ οἶδα οἴομαι εἰδέναι – "I don't assume that I know whatever I don't know."